10 THINGS YOU SHOULD KNOW ABOUT COPYRIGHT

COPYRIGHT PROTECTS CREATIVE WORK — YOURS, MINE, EVERYONE'S!

1. We're all both consumers and creators of creative work. As consumers, we watch movies, listen to music, read books, and more! As creators, we take photos, write songs, make videos, etc.

2. Copyright protects creative work, so people can't generally copy or share or perform other people's work without permission.

3. Copyright comes from the Constitution. Its purpose is to promote more creativity. The idea is that letting each of us decide what happens to our own creations will encourage us to keep creating.

4. All creative work is protected by copyright as soon as it's written down or recorded or saved—and not just work by professional artists or big studios. Copyright protects all of us—our photos on Instagram and everything we write or create.

5. If you copy or share other people's creative works without permission, that's called copyright infringement. Examples:

6. Downloading music, movies, ebooks, or games from illegal sources that operate without artists' permission.
7. Uploading your collection of music, movies, ebooks, or games for your friends to copy.

Copyright infringement is illegal and carries serious penalties.

BUT COPYRIGHT DOESN'T COVER EVERYTHING

1. Copyright gives a lot of protection, but it also has limitations. Not everything gets copyright protection. Facts and ideas are not protected by copyright, neither are US Government documents, like NASA photos and reports by federal agencies.

2. Another limitation of copyright is "fair use," which allows us to copy and re-use copyrighted work without the artist's permission in certain, limited ways that are still fair to the creator.

3. When you re-use portions of someone else's work for a school project—like using images or songs for a presentation in class—that's a fair use situation. You don't need the author's permission.

4. Copyright protection doesn't last forever. Eventually it expires, and the creative work falls into the "public domain." Works in the public domain are free to re-use and share however you want.

5. Some creators are happy to share their creative work. They use a licensing system for sharing called Creative Commons. You can find millions of CC work that are free to share or re-use.